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Two Page Paper

The Individual & Culture in Early Psychological Anthropological Works

Works by Franz Boas, Bronisław Malinowski, Edward Sapir, and Ruth Benedict all stress the importance of culture in shaping human behavioral patterns and individuals' identities. In the early 20th century, Boas introduced the idea of cultural relativism which proposed that cultures are essentially incomparable to each other; if two cultures have similarly appearing anthropological phenomena, their psychological characteristics may be completely distinct from one another, making deeper psychological comparisons essentially useless (Boas, 375). Cultural relativism helped Boas pioneer the idea that race is a social construct (Benedict later echoed this), attributing racial divisions to differences in culture rather than any inherent biological differences (Boas, 372; Benedict, 16). Malinowski, also in the early 20th century, conducted anthropological research with cultural relativism in mind. Malinowski, knowing that there were different cultural and social realities, aimed to find out how best to study culture. In the Trobriand islands, he took the approach of immersion and field work to uncover, "the typical ways of thinking and feeling, corresponding to the institutions and culture of a given community" (Malinowski, 23). As Malinowski elaborates on *how* to do this kind of research, he emphasizes studying social phenomena to their "full extent" and culture in "all its aspects" (Malinowski, 11). The idea that we should study cultures in their totality was strongly echoed in Ruth Benedict's comparison of Gestalt psychology in individuals to the study of cultures. Highlighting the cruciality of a subjective framework in studying both culture and psychology, the Gestalt framework helped Benedict express cultures as "articulated wholes" - a unique totality that is more than just the sum of its parts. Likening the study of culture to the individual, Benedict proposes that studying the configuration of an individual's personality is remarkably similar to studying the

configuration of culture in society (Benedict, 46-51). Sapir takes this one step further, suggesting that studying the social and the individual is not as distinct as many think; the social and the individual are always simultaneously at play, and any stress on one or the other in the study of a certain behavioral pattern is the fault of the observer. Early on in Sapir's text on exploring the unconscious patterns of behavior in society, Sapir assumes, "that any kind of psychology that explains the behavior of the individual also explains the behavior of society" (Sapir, 115). The simultaneity of society being explained by individual behavior and individual behavior being constituted by society becomes quite evident here.

Sapir and Benedict greatly expand on the idea that an individual's behavior in society is culturally constituted. As to how a society's culture is developed and integrated into each individual's behaviors, they both cite a process of selection; patterns and traits in a society are selected, rejected, and/or elaborated on to define the nature of a culture (Sapir 116; Benedict 23-25, 46). Benedict uses the differing emphasis on puberty in different societies to exemplify the selection process. Although puberty may seem like a very individually constituted process, Benedict argues that puberty is a culturally, rather than biologically, constituted phenomenon; a boy or girl does not "begin adulthood" until their adulthood or puberty is recognized by their community (Benedict, 25). While an outsider may see the lack of recognition of a Samoan girl's puberty by her community as abnormal, Sapir and Boas would both label the behavior of the girl's culture and the changes in the girl's behavior through her adolescence as unconscious (Benedict, 30; Boas, 377; Sapir, 122). Sapir also provides an example of a seemingly individual behavior found to be socially constituted as a result of unconscious patterning. Breathing, at first, is seen as an individual behavior - individuals can hold their breath, heave, blow, and hiss at their discretion. But, if we look at breathing in a cultural context, we see that, "there are polite and impolite ways of breathing" and, if one were to breathe in a style unlike any pattern we are used to in our own cultures, we would likely deem it abnormal.

Works Cited

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